The Water Cycle - Part 1: Evaporation and Condensation

Water is always moving around the Earth. This is called the water cycle. The Sun provides the energy that drives it.

Evaporation: the Sun heats water in the sea, rivers, lakes and puddles. Some of the liquid water turns into an invisible gas called water vapour and rises into the air. Heat makes evaporation faster, so washing dries quickly on a hot sunny day.

Condensation: high in the sky the air is cold. When water vapour cools it turns back into tiny drops of liquid water. Millions of these tiny drops together form clouds. You can see condensation at home when water drops form on the outside of a cold glass, or when a mirror fogs up in the bathroom.